

## Religion in Northern Europe in the Iron age

Main sources of knowledge about Celtic religion are the material remains of the period dating from about 500 B.C.E. at Lake Neuchatel in Switzerland.

The Celts culture included the use of horses and iron weapons. they appeared in the early 7th cent. B.C.E. in central Europe east of the Rhine. They spread into the Balkans, north Italy and France and reached the British isles by the 3rd Cent. B.C.E.

Eventually their culture was destroyed by the Romans and the spread of the Germanic tribes.

Their religion can be cautiously reconstructed. One recurrent feature is the importance of natural sites as focal points for ritual, notably sacred groves, forest clearings, hilltops and expanses of water.

Many things have been recovered from lakes, marshes, wells and rivers which were apparently thrown in as offerings.

For a long time it was thought that natural sites were  
RAC DU archeology has revealed an ancient native tradition of man-made enclosures

### Opening

shrines and temples.  
enclosures.

in the earth haide OF around the  
sometimes very deep, contain pottery and both human and animal bones as well

as other things used for offering.

Clearly such openings in the earth were believed to be means of access to an underworld of supernatural powers.

many temples have heads and actual skulls displayed in niches around doorways. The Celtic fondness for head-hunting is well attested by classical authors and Irish tales. Besides being trophies they may have served magical and necromantic purposes.

### Symbols

Few have survived as they were probably made of wood. There are some bronze masks and some pre-roman stone statues.

The wheel, swastika and spiral were attributes of a sky-god who controlled sun and lightning.

Neck rings symbolized authority and often appear on

representations of the gods.

Janus-headed statues and four sided column with four identical faces may symbolize omniscience.

Many animals, particularly boars, rams possessed supernatural significance.

rams and snakes,

Ritual

Celtic religion clearly had elaborate ritual  
Organized priesthood.

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The Druids were the priests whose chief functions were to preserve and transmit myths, legends and poetry, and

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probably also tribal history and law; to organize sacrifices, interpret omens, and carry out magical rites; and to act as arbitrators in lawsuits and bloodfeuds.

Celtic burials testify to a strong belief in an afterlife, Valhalla. They provided food for the journey.

This is not unusual, but the belief that after some years the soul passes into another body and that people may live again in a child descended from and named after them is unusual.

Celtic divinities in Roman times

Roman rulers tried to suppress human sacrifice and the organized Druid priesthood.

Tried to get Celts to identify their gods with Roman deities.

Julius Caesar states that the chief god of the Gauls was one who protected craftsmen and traders and gave wealth. The Goddess of healing, of arts and crafts, a sky-god, a war-god and an underworld ancestral god.

There are many gods and goddess and much devotion to gods and goddesses of healing, especially at thermal or medicinal

springs.

Irish Divinities

Ireland never underwent any Romanization so it preserved many archaic myths and hero-legends.

In their view the world of magic, portents and taboo is

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not remote but the supernatural and human constantly mix and

interact.

this world lies beneath the Irish lakes and mounds and can invade human lives or be invaded by people.

Two Gods are described in considerable detail. Dagda (the good god), warrior chieftain, father and magician. The other is Lug (also known in Gaul), he too is a warrior, magician, poet and master of every craft.

It is typical of Celtic gods to combine varied functions, reflecting all the qualities of an ideal leader.

#### Irish Goddess

Many Irish goddesses are maternal figures, bestowing fertility on crops, herds and men.

Some are river goddesses, others personifications of Ireland who grant love to kings.

Some are macabre, haunting battlefields, appearing in bird form or as hags and use sorcery.  
(queen of Phantoms.

This includes Morrigan

Gods or heroes who mate with them learn magical arts of war, though he who rejects them meet a rapid doom.

four major Irish festivals which were probably common  
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c world.

Sadain on Nov. 1 marked the start of winter and the  
new year. On this day and 1

especially the

natural and supernatural worlds mingled, and the forces from  
the otherworld threatened humanity. This is now of course

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Halloween followed by all saints day (Nov. 1) on the  
Christian calendar.

little is known about Feb. 1 celebration but the spring  
feast was Beltane on May 1. Cattle were driven to pasture,  
passing between bonfires to avert disease.

The fourth was on August 1 called Lughnasadh, Lug's  
wedding: it was linked with goddesses and may have involved  
a ritual marriage to assure good harvests.

These festivals were celebrated at great gatherings  
lasting several days with dancing, horse racing and  
sacrifices.

#### Germanic Religion

Archeology indicates many links between Germanic  
religious practices and those of the Celts and of Bronze age

peoples.

Most worship in the open with small wooden shrines to house images of the gods. Sacrifices done in the open.

unlikely that priests ever formed a separate social group.

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general it was the king or local chieftain who carried out public rituals at assemblies and festivals, though the snaman!

also had

in religious life.

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las have survived.

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of repeated votive offerings continued for centuries.

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War Gods

The cult of war gods is mentioned by many in Roman times by Tacitus.

Tacitus.

Mars and Mercury among them as interpreted by

Mars was probably Tiwaz after whom Tuesday is named. He is wise and valiant and the rune named after him was put on weapons to ensure success.

Tiwaz must have been more than war god; his name (related to Zeus and deus) shows he was originally a sky-god and there are signs that he assured law and justice. By the viking age he was almost forgotten.

Wotan (the one the romans called Mercury) called Odin in Scandanavia, Woden in England bestowed victory and protected princely heroes but his power was that of a divine sorcerer, master of occult terrors: he was also lord of the dead and death in battle was the ultimate fate of his worshippers.

Human victims sacrificed to him were despatched by simultaneous spear-thrust and hanging, and cremation was associated with his cult. He carried a spear and was accompanied by eagles, ravens or wolves. Wednesday is named after him. His cult was practiced in Sweden, Denmark and England.

The Valkyries

Odin's female emissaries, the Valkyries grant men victory or summon them to Valhalla.

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Often described as beautiful women in armour riding through the air bestowing their love on living heroes and serving wine to the dead.

They can also appear as gigantic hags who appear before battle, riding wolves, sprinkling blood, or weaving on loom of human guts and skulls.

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Deities of war necessarily present a dual aspect.

Thor

name means  
storm-god.

"thunder" he was a sky-god, especially a  
the Romans identified him with Jupiter.

since

he ruled weather, he was invoked by seafarers and farmers and was especially popular to the Vikings.

sworn on rings He

enforced law and justice, oaths were  
sacred to him and the Icelandic assembly always began on  
Thursday.

In myths, he is a mighty fighter always crushing giants and monsters who would otherwise destroy the world.

by the close of the period, Thor was the god most widely revered, both in Scandinavia and in Viking settlements as universal protector.

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Fertile Deities

were worshipped in Roman times by the

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and to nature.

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they gave fertility to men  
earth mother" Nerthus, whose emblem!

was carried

round **the** fields in a covered wagon, and then washed in a lake by slaves who were then drowned.

In **later** centuries there were many goddesses who had much in common, they gave fruitfulness to the land, **wealth**, love and **fertility** to men and women, and luck to children.

Freyja was the best known, the goddess of sexual love, magic and divination. her brother/lover Freyr was a chief **fertility**-god who like Freyja was a patron of love, marriage, peace and plenty. He loved an underworld giantess which indicates his marriage to the earth.

There were several types of lesser deities such as elves, 'earth spirits'

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guardian-goddesses and the like.

the dead

Odin's Valhalla was one concept where heroes feast **ti11** the end of the world.

the goddess Hel rules a dark realm where people were conceived as traveling on foot or wagon.

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traces of belief in reincarnation tho wide variety were buried with much equipment. less wealthy people were buried or burnt with a few weapons, clothes, ornaments or tools and were plain or covered with stones forming a

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ne of a ship.

The burial of **the** dead in actual ships was prac

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**the** viking settlements in the 7th to the 9th century were very lavish.

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Icelandic cosmology is best known as most Germanic myth is **not** known.

creation myths include the mingling of ice and fire in the void, the dismemberment of a primeval bisexual giant, a flood, and the creation of humans from tree-trunks.

The completed universe consisted of various worlds, of gods, people, giants, and underworld beings—all linked by, or indeed contained in, the World Tree Yggdrasil.

This sacred archetypal tree was life giving and protective, decaying yet ever renewed and would endure eternally.

Loki the trickster god, in the myth of the end becomes demonic and destroys most of the earth and gods. but it will rise again from the sea and a few surviving gods and people will found a better world.

than will reappear, and the cycle will begin again.